

NC.3 Inspection Sequence

The order North Carolina inspections happen in, what each inspector is actually looking at, and a log to record every result as you go.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. North Carolina permits are administered by 100 counties and dozens of municipalities, and local requirements vary. Confirm every item with the inspections department that will issue your permit before you rely on it. Your permit card lists the inspections your job requires — it governs.

WHAT THE STATE SETS AND WHAT YOUR COUNTY SETS

The **definitions** below are statewide. They come from Section 107 of the North Carolina Administrative Code and Policies, part of the State Building Code, and they say what condition the work must be in before each inspection can be called. The **list of inspections your particular job needs**, and the order your department calls them in, is local — it is printed on your permit card. Where the two differ, your permit card and your inspector govern.

The statute itself does not enumerate inspections. G.S. 160D-1113 simply directs local inspectors to *"make as many inspections thereof as may be necessary to satisfy them that the work is being done according to the provisions of any applicable State and local laws and of the terms of the permit."* That is why counties vary in how they bundle framing with rough-in, or insulation with framing.

You must be there — every time

"If a building permit has been obtained by an owner exempt from licensure under G.S. 87-1(b)(2), no inspection shall be conducted without the owner being present, unless the plans for the building were drawn and sealed by an architect licensed pursuant to Chapter 83A." (G.S. 160D-1113)

This is a command on the inspector, not a suggestion to you. Note it says **architect** — not engineer. Plan your work weeks around it.

N.C.G.S. § 160D-1113; 2018 North Carolina Administrative Code and Policies § 107. The 2018 edition of the State Building Code is the edition in effect (NC Office of State Fire Marshal, Codes — Current and Past, verified August 2026). The 2024 edition has been adopted but its effective date remains deferred; it may be used as an alternative method on request. Confirm the edition your county is enforcing before you submit plans.

THE SEQUENCE — WHAT MUST BE COMPLETE BEFORE YOU CALL

Standard North Carolina residential inspection sequence

Inspection	What must be complete / what is verified	Code
1. Footing	Trenches excavated, all grade stakes installed, all reinforcing steel and supports in place and tied, and all necessary forms and bulkheads in place and braced — before any concrete is placed.	§ 107.1.1
2. Under-slab	After all materials and equipment that the concrete slab will conceal are complete — under-slab plumbing, electrical, vapor barrier, fill. Certain unheated garage slabs, sidewalks and driveways are excepted for one- and two-family dwellings.	§ 107.1.2
3. Foundation / crawl space	After all foundation supports are installed. In a crawl space this is where piers, girders, sill anchorage, and grade clearances are looked at.	§ 107.1.3
4. Building framing	After roof framing (excluding permanent roof coverings), wall, ceiling and floor framing is complete with appropriate blocking, bracing and firestopping in place. Pipes, chimneys and vents, roof and chimney flashing, insulation baffles, and any lintels bolted to the framing must be visible.	§ 107.1.4
5. Rough-in (electrical, plumbing, mechanical)	When all building framing and every part of the electrical, plumbing, fire protection or heating-ventilation-cooling system that will be hidden from view has been placed — but before any wall or ceiling finish or any insulation is installed. Many NC counties call framing and rough-in together; some call each trade separately.	§ 107.1.5
6. Insulation	After an approved framing and rough-in inspection, and after the permanent roof covering is installed, with all insulation and vapor retarders in place — before any wall or ceiling covering is applied.	§ 107.1.6
7. Fire protection	Wherever material is used for fire protection purposes. You must notify the department once the material is in place; it may not be concealed until inspected and approved.	§ 107.1.7
8. Final — each trade	After completion of the work authorized under each technical code. Building, electrical, plumbing and mechanical each get their own final. The building final is the one that releases the certificate.	§ 107.1.8

Definitions quoted from the 2018 North Carolina Administrative Code and Policies § 107 (Inspections), whose § 107.1 directs that "the inspection department shall perform the following inspections" and then names these eight. The NC Residential Code's own § R109 simply points there. Note that an earlier edition numbered framing and rough-in in the opposite order — the descriptive text is stable, the two subsection numbers swapped. Verified August 2026.

WHAT AN INSPECTOR MAY AND MAY NOT DO

G.S. 160D-1104 gives you more leverage than most owner-builders realise. Worth knowing before your first difficult inspection:

- The inspector *"shall conduct all inspections requested by the permit holder for each scheduled inspection,"* and must tell you where the work fails. They are **prohibited from requiring affidavits** attesting to compliance in lieu of actually inspecting Residential Code work. (§ 160D-1104(c))
- On a re-inspection, new violations found on items **already approved** may not delay a temporary CO, and **no re-inspection fee may be charged** for those items. (§ 160D-1104(d))
- Cancel more than one business day ahead and they may not charge you a fee or fail the inspection. (§ 160D-1104(d2))
- Every department must run an **informal internal review** of inspection decisions, starting with the inspector's supervisor — whose name, phone and email must be provided with your permit. Use it before you escalate. (§ 160D-1104(e))
- Counties cannot invent extra **routin**e inspections beyond the State Building Code list without Residential Code Council approval — though they may still inspect for unforeseen or unique circumstances. (§ 160D-1104(d))

*One thing the statutes do **not** give you: a deadline. There is no numeric statutory turnaround for an inspection request — G.S. 160D-1104(b) requires only "the making of any necessary inspections in a timely manner." Any 24- or 48-hour figure you have heard is local practice. The hard clock in North Carolina law applies to residential plan review, not inspections (§ 160D-1110(b)) — see NC.2.*

THE CERTIFICATE AT THE END

"At the conclusion of all work done under a building permit, the appropriate inspector shall make a final inspection, and, if the completed work complies with all applicable State and local laws and with the terms of the permit, the inspector shall issue a certificate of compliance."

North Carolina's statutory name is **certificate of compliance**; most counties and every lender will call it the certificate of occupancy.

A **temporary certificate of occupancy** may be issued for a stated period if the inspector finds the building may safely be occupied before final completion. Moving in before either one issues is a **Class 1 misdemeanor** — the most serious penalty named anywhere in this kit.

N.C.G.S. § 160D-1116(a), (b), (c).

WHEN AN INSPECTION GOES WRONG

Failures, changes, stop orders, and expiry

Situation	What to do	Authority
You failed	Get the written correction notice, fix exactly what it names, and re-call. Re-inspection fees and how soon you may re-call are local — ask at your first inspection so it is not a surprise at your third.	local

Failures, changes, stop orders, and expiry

Situation	What to do	Authority
You need to change something	Get written approval <i>before</i> you build it. No change or deviation from the approved application, plans or permit may be made until the inspection department specifically approves it in writing, unless the Code clearly permits it.	§ 160D-1112
You got a stop order	You may appeal a stop order alleging a Building Code violation to the State Fire Marshal within five days , in writing, copying the local inspector. No further work may proceed in violation of the order while the appeal is pending.	§ 160D-1114
Your permit went stale	A permit expires six months after issuance if work has not commenced, and expires immediately if work is discontinued for 12 months after commencement. Local ordinance may set a shorter commencement window.	§ 160D-1111

Guides that say a North Carolina permit "is valid for 18 months" are describing a local practice, not the statute — § 160D-1111 sets six months to commence and 12 months of inactivity thereafter.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Fill this in as it happens, not from memory. If a result is ever disputed, or a later inspector questions earlier work, this page and your photos are the record you have.

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Footing					
Under-slab					
Foundation / crawl					
Framing					
Electrical rough-in					
Plumbing rough-in					
Mechanical rough-in					
Insulation					
Fire protection					

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Final — electrical					
Final — plumbing					
Final — mechanical					
Final — building					

Certificate of compliance issued: _____ Number: _____

Sources (verified August 2026, General Statutes at ncleg.gov). Inspections of work in progress, and the owner-present rule with its architect-sealed exception — § 160D-1113. Inspector duties and applicant protections: all requested inspections conducted and no affidavits in lieu — § 160D-1104(c); no re-inspection fee or TCO delay for newly-noted items already approved, and the limit on locally-added routine inspections — § 160D-1104(d); no fee if cancelled over one business day ahead — § 160D-1104(d2); informal internal review — § 160D-1104(e); "timely manner" and no numeric deadline — § 160D-1104(b). Changes need written approval — § 160D-1112. Stop-order appeal within five days — § 160D-1114. Permit expiry — § 160D-1111. Final inspection, certificate of compliance, temporary CO and the Class 1 occupancy penalty — § 160D-1116. The eight required inspections and their definitions — 2018 NC Administrative Code and Policies § 107.1.1–.1.8, to which NC Residential Code § R109 defers. The 2018 State Building Code is the edition in effect — ncosfm.gov, Codes Current and Past.